APPROVED ON NOVEMBER 4, 2026
BY THE BOARD OF COUNTY COMMISSIONERS
AT THE WEEKLY BUSINESS SESSION

City/County Monthly Update: October 27, 2026
11:00 a.m. - Board of Commissioners Conference Room
Attending: Commissioners Ron A. Smith; Colene M. Martin; Gary L. Richardson; and Nikole Guzman, Recorder
Additional Attendees: Councilor Rick Riker, City of Grants Pass; Thomas Peterson, Solid Waste Specialist; Cliff Scherf, Mayor, and Aaron Cubic, City Manager, were unable to attend.

Chair Ron Smith called the joint meeting to order at 11:00 a.m.

Commissioners Richardson and Martin stated they had no potential conflicts of interest.

1. **Discussion with City Representatives**

The City and County held an open discussion focused primarily on vehicle camping, illegal dumping, solid waste enforcement, and conditions at Devil's Slide. No formal agenda beyond the joint discussion was presented.

Vehicle Camping / Parker's Place. The City and County revisited the prior discussion of whether County property might be available for a vehicle-camping area. It was reported that a review of County-owned property did not identify a suitable site. Thomas Peterson explained that Josephine County adopted hazardous-conditions provisions for public property in 2023 after recurring camping, solid-waste, drug-use, and cleanup problems, including costly cleanups in Wolf Creek and other locations. He advised that Public Health does not support establishing a County car-camping area at this time because of the likely environmental, public-health, law-enforcement, staffing, and financial impacts. The City representative also indicated that a low-barrier or vehicle-camping proposal was unlikely to receive support under current conditions. The concept was left for possible future discussion rather than advanced.

Illegal Dumping, Solid Waste, and Tire Disposal. The group discussed whether higher disposal rates contribute to illegal dumping, including conditions around the former Kerby landfill. Peterson said his experience suggests dumping is often a behavioral or cultural issue rather than strictly a cost issue, noting recent cases involving newer vehicles bypassing lawful disposal sites. He described recent enforcement successes using photographs, video, discarded mail, social media, and coordination with law enforcement. Participants praised Clean Sweep and Friends of Country Living for cleanup efforts and discussed expanding tire-disposal opportunities and similar programs countywide. Peterson noted that Public Health now has an online complaint form and can also receive anonymous reports when residents are uncomfortable contacting law enforcement directly.

Devil's Slide / City-Owned Property. Peterson reported that he and a Sheriff's deputy recently spent several hours at Devil's Slide meeting with residents and people occupying camps. Based on the field visit and mapping provided by nearby residents, most occupied camps are on City of Grants Pass property located outside the city limits and therefore within County code-enforcement jurisdiction. Peterson estimated approximately 10 to 20 people may be present at a given time. He explained that the County would address solid-waste and hazardous-condition violations in the same manner as violations on other property: the property owner would be notified, a voluntary-compliance plan established, and the site reinspected, with further enforcement available if needed. The County will continue patrol and education efforts on County property to discourage new camps. Fire danger, open burning, nearby residences, and railroad property were identified as significant concerns. The discussion distinguished the broader homelessness issue from the County's responsibility to enforce public-health and solid-waste codes.

Public Education, Staffing, and Interagency Coordination. Peterson reported that Program Specialist Caitlin Brown would begin work the following week and assist with reviewing older compliance cases and organizing field work. He said additional field capacity may eventually be needed as the program rebuilds.

The group discussed continued coordination with the Sheriff's Office and resident-deputy program, fire districts, the Solid Waste Agency, DEQ, BLM, ODOT, neighborhood groups, and volunteer cleanup organizations. The Board encouraged Peterson to work with Public Information Officer Thomas Gray, Public Health leadership, the City of Grants Pass, and the City of Cave Junction on a public-education campaign, potentially including a community slogan or contest to discourage dumping and promote stewardship. Councilor Riker agreed to relay the Devil's Slide discussion to the City. The County also discussed exploring another tire-disposal event and periodically reevaluating program needs and progress.

No decisions were made.

2. Other/Additional Subject Matters from Commissioners - ORS 192.640(1)

No additional matters were presented.

The meeting adjourned at 11:59 a.m.